

Landauer-Based Thermodynamic Model for the Minimum Quasiparticle Density in Al/AlOx/Al Josephson Junction Transmon Qubits

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The background quasiparticle density $x_{\text{qp}} \sim 10^{-7}$ observed in best-isolated Al/AlOx/Al transmon qubits has resisted explanation for over two decades despite systematic elimination of known external sources including cosmic rays, infrared radiation, and environmental radioactivity. We propose that this minimum density is endogenous — the thermodynamic cost of maintaining quantum coherence against decoherence pressure from the oxide barrier’s two-level fluctuator (TLS) bath. The junction continuously refreshes its quantum state at the TLS correlation rate τ_{TLS}^{-1} , paying a Landauer erasure cost $k_B T_{\text{gap}} \ln 2$ per refresh cycle, where $T_{\text{gap}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B = 2.11$ K is the gap temperature of the Al encoding surface. Each pinhole site has a participation volume $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi \lambda_L^3$, obtained from the London equation Green’s function, where $\lambda_L = 50$ nm is the London penetration depth of aluminum. Using published material parameters and no adjustable fit parameters, we obtain $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} = 6.5 \times 10^{-8}$, a factor of 1.5 below the observed floor, with exact agreement at $\tau_{\text{TLS}} \approx 20$ μs within the published AlOx range. This mechanism is consistent with nine independent published observations. We identify the dimensionless invariant $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} \cdot n_{\text{cp}} \cdot \tau_{\text{TLS}} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3 / \tau_{\text{qp}} = \ln 2$ as a material-independent relation testable on a single device. Within this framework, the result suggests an endogenous T_1 ceiling for Al/AlOx transmons that would not be substantially reduced by improved shielding or substrate engineering alone.

INTRODUCTION

Nonequilibrium quasiparticles (QPs) are broken Cooper pairs that limit coherence in superconducting qubits through tunneling across Josephson junctions (JJs). Two decades of measurements on Al/AlOx/Al transmon qubits consistently reveal a background QP density $x_{\text{qp}} = n_{\text{qp}}/n_{\text{cp}} \sim 10^{-7}$, where n_{cp} is the Cooper pair density [1, 2]. This floor persists after systematic reduction of every known external source: infrared photons [3], environmental radioactivity [4], and cosmic rays [5].

The most stringent test is the underground laboratory experiment of Ref. [6], in which the identical qubit was operated both at the surface and at the Gran Sasso underground facility (LNGS), reducing the muon flux by a factor of thirty. De Dominicis *et al.* observed identical $T_1 \approx 80$ μs at both sites despite this stark difference in radiation levels, concluding that intrinsic noise rather than environmental radiation dominates decoherence at current qubit lifetimes. This result rules out cosmic radiation as the dominant source of the background x_{qp} floor under present operating conditions.

A second important observation comes from Connolly *et al.* [7], who measured the energy distribution of QPs in a transmon and found *nonequilibrium density coexisting with equilibrium energy distribution*. External sources — cosmic rays, IR photons, radioactivity — deposit QPs *above* the gap; these cool to equilibrium on a timescale much shorter than τ_{qp} . The observation of excess density *with* thermalized energy is consistent with a *continuous, slow, endogenous* source rather than a *bursty exogenous* one.

A third observation from Ref. [8] shows that the background QPT rate is largely independent of T_1 and capacitor pad geometry at low temperatures, while the QPT rate is sensitive to the quality of the AlOx barrier itself — specifically, the presence of high-transmission sites (pinholes) with reduced effective gap $\Delta_1 \approx 0.1 \Delta_0$.

These observations together are consistent with an endogenous source localized at the junction barrier. Here we propose that source: the Landauer cost of maintaining quantum coherence against the TLS bath, paid continuously at the junction’s high-transmission sites.

THE MECHANISM

We now propose a specific mechanism consistent with the observations above. The three central assumptions — (i) that coherence maintenance against the TLS bath constitutes a Landauer erasure process, (ii) that the operative bath temperature is $T_{\text{gap}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B$, and (iii) that the relevant volume per pinhole site is $\pi \lambda_L^3$ — are each stated explicitly below and developed from established superconductor theory in the Theoretical Foundations section below.

The encoding surface and the maintenance cost

The Al/AlOx/Al Josephson junction maintains a quantum superposition of charge states against continuous decoherence pressure from the TLS bath in the AlOx barrier and at the metal-oxide interfaces. The junction does not perform this maintenance only when a decoherence event occurs; it maintains coherence continuously,

refreshing its quantum state at the rate set by the fastest TLS fluctuation it must resist. This is analogous to a control system that re-executes its state estimate at fixed intervals regardless of whether external conditions have changed: the cost is structural, not conditional.

The relevant timescale is τ_{TLS} , the correlation time of the $1/f$ charge fluctuators in the AlOx barrier. These are well-characterized experimentally: Burnett *et al.* [12] established through long-timescale measurements of superconducting microresonators that interacting TLS produce $1/f$ noise persisting to timescales from $\sim 1 \mu\text{s}$ to $> 10^3 \mu\text{s}$. We use the representative value $\tau_{\text{TLS}} = 30 \mu\text{s}$ (middle of the published range).

The irreversibility enters as follows. Each TLS fluctuation perturbs the phase coherence of the condensate at the pinhole site; suppressing that perturbation requires the system to discard information about which TLS configuration caused it [18]. By Landauer's principle [17], erasing one bit of information from a system coupled to a heat bath at temperature T_H dissipates a minimum energy $k_B T_H \ln 2$. The logical irreversibility is precisely this erasure: the condensate restores its phase at the cost of discarding the record of the TLS perturbation. The relevant bath temperature T_H is that of the encoding surface itself, set by the superconducting gap: $T_{\text{gap}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B = 2.11 \text{ K}$ (justified below in the bath temperature derivation).

The high-transmission pinhole sites

Kurter *et al.* [8] demonstrated that Al/AlOx/Al junctions contain high-transmission pathways through the oxide with effective gap $\Delta_1 \approx 5\text{--}30 \mu\text{eV}$, approximately 10% of the bulk Al gap $\Delta_0 \approx 185 \mu\text{eV}$. These pinhole sites dominate QPT at millikelvin temperatures. They note that the London penetration depth of Al is $\lambda_L \approx 50 \text{ nm}$ [9].

Each pinhole site has a participation volume $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi\lambda_L^3$: the volume within which the Al condensate participates coherently in a phase-erasure event at that site, derived exactly in the Theoretical Foundations section below from the London equation Green's function. The London penetration depth λ_L sets the scale over which the condensate screens magnetic perturbations and over which the superfluid density responds to local phase disruptions; the factor π arises from the phase-weighted participation integral. This choice is physically distinct from the bulk superconducting coherence length $\xi_0 \approx 1.6 \mu\text{m}$ for Al, which characterizes pair-breaking over long distances and would give a volume $\sim 10^4$ times larger — inconsistent with the localized, pinhole-site geometry identified by Kurter *et al.* [8]. Prediction 3 requires $\pi\lambda_L^3$ to scale correctly across materials, providing a direct test.

The temperature structure and the relevant heat bath

The junction operates within a temperature hierarchy (Fig. 1):

$$T_{\text{CMB}} = 2.725 \text{ K} > T_{\text{gap}} = 2.11 \text{ K} > T_{\text{fridge}} \approx 15 \text{ mK} \quad (1)$$

The Landauer erasure cost is paid to the heat bath with which the encoding surface is in thermal contact. The junction condensate is not in contact with the dilution refrigerator as a heat bath in the relevant sense: the fridge removes phonons from the substrate, but the condensate at the pinhole site thermalizes to the energy scale of its own gap, $\Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B = 2.11 \text{ K}$, not to the fridge temperature. This is because quasiparticle excitations cost energy $\sim \Delta_{\text{Al}}$; the thermal population at $T_{\text{fridge}} = 15 \text{ mK}$ is exponentially suppressed ($e^{-\Delta/k_B T_{\text{fridge}}} \sim 10^{-630}$), so the condensate is effectively decoupled from the fridge as a bath for pair-breaking processes. The operative bath temperature for the Landauer cost is therefore T_{gap} , the temperature at which the condensate itself can exchange energy with quasiparticle excitations.

This assignment makes a sharp prediction: $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$ should be independent of T_{fridge} for all $T_{\text{fridge}} \ll T_{\text{gap}}$. This prediction is consistent with Ristè *et al.* [2], who observed no change in x_{qp} as T_{fridge} was varied below 150 mK. That observation is difficult to reconcile with models in which the relevant bath temperature is simply T_{fridge} , and is consistent with — though does not uniquely establish — identifying T_{gap} as the operative Landauer temperature in the present framework.

THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS

We now derive each of the three central assumptions from established superconductor theory. These derivations replace the assertions of the Mechanism section above with results that follow from BCS theory, the London equations, and the Landauer-Bennett theorem.

Derivation of $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi\lambda_L^3$ from the London equations

A tunneling event at a pinhole site creates a localized phase disturbance in the Al condensate. We derive the spatial extent of this disturbance — and therefore the volume of condensate involved in each erasure event — from the London equation.

In the Coulomb gauge, the London equation for the vector potential $\mathbf{A}$ in the bulk superconductor satisfies:

$$\nabla^2 \mathbf{A} = \frac{\mathbf{A}}{\lambda_L^2} \quad (2)$$

Figure 1. Temperature Structure of the Al/AlOx/Al Junction Encoding Surface
 $T_{\text{CMB}} = 2.725 \text{ K (ambient)} > T_{\text{gap}} = 2.11 \text{ K (encoding surface)} > T_{\text{fridge}} = 15 \text{ mK (dilution refrigerator)}$

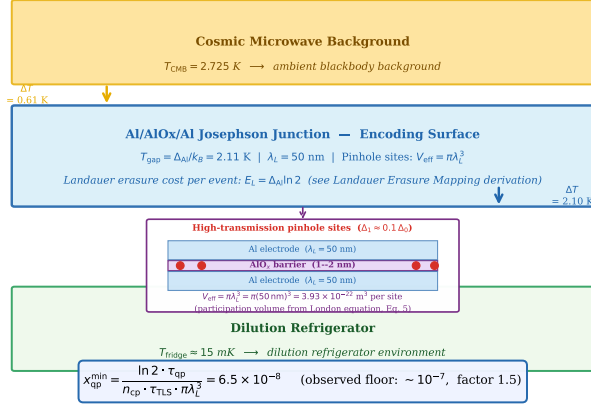


FIG. 1. Temperature structure of the Al/AlOx/Al junction encoding surface. The junction sits between the ambient CMB ($T_{\text{CMB}} = 2.725 \text{ K}$) and the dilution refrigerator environment ($T_{\text{fridge}} \approx 15 \text{ mK}$). The Landauer maintenance cost is paid at $T_{\text{gap}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B = 2.11 \text{ K}$, the gap temperature of the Al encoding surface. Inset: Al/AlOx/Al junction cross-section showing the 1–2 nm AlOx tunnel barrier with high-transmission pinhole sites (red dots, $\Delta_1 \approx 0.1 \Delta_0$, Ref. [8]). Each pinhole has participation volume $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi\lambda_L^3 = \pi(50 \text{ nm})^3$, where $\lambda_L = 50 \text{ nm}$ is the London penetration depth of Al [8], derived from the London equation (see the participation volume derivation below). The resulting formula $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} = 6.5 \times 10^{-8}$ is shown at bottom.

A point-like current perturbation at a pinhole site ($\mathbf{r} = 0$) acts as a localized source. The Green's function solution in three dimensions is:

$$\mathbf{A}(\mathbf{r}) = \frac{\mu_0 J_{\text{pin}}}{4\pi} \frac{e^{-r/\lambda_L}}{r} \quad (3)$$

The condensate phase gradient couples to $\mathbf{A}$ via the London relation $\nabla\phi = (2e/\hbar)\mathbf{A}$, giving a phase disturbance that decays as $\delta\phi(r) \sim e^{-r/\lambda_L}$ for $r \gg 0$.

The effective participation volume — the volume of condensate that meaningfully contributes to the erasure event — is defined by the phase-weighted integral:

$$V_{\text{eff}} = \int \left| \frac{\delta\phi(\mathbf{r})}{\delta\phi(0)} \right|^2 d^3r = 4\pi \int_0^\infty e^{-2r/\lambda_L} r^2 dr \quad (4)$$

Evaluating exactly via the substitution $u = 2r/\lambda_L$:

$$V_{\text{eff}} = 4\pi \cdot \frac{\lambda_L^3}{8} \int_0^\infty u^2 e^{-u} du = 4\pi \cdot \frac{\lambda_L^3}{8} \cdot \Gamma(3) = \pi\lambda_L^3 \quad (5)$$

This result is exact. The participation volume is $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi\lambda_L^3$, determined entirely by the London screening length.

It is essential to distinguish λ_L from the BCS coherence length $\xi_0 \approx 1600 \text{ nm}$ for bulk Al [21]. These characterize fundamentally different physics: ξ_0 is the amplitude coherence length, governing pair-breaking processes over

which $|\Delta(\mathbf{r})|$ recovers; λ_L is the phase screening length, governing the spatial extent of phase disturbances in the superfluid. Since Landauer erasure here involves the irreversible discarding of phase information — not pair-breaking — λ_L is the correct scale. Using ξ_0 instead would give a volume $(\xi_0/\lambda_L)^3 = (1600/50)^3 \approx 3 \times 10^4$ times larger, yielding $x_{\text{qp}} \sim 10^{-11}$, five orders of magnitude below the observed floor. The two length scales are cleanly separated in Al (Ginzburg-Landau parameter $\kappa = \lambda_L/\xi_0 \approx 0.03 \ll 1$), making this system particularly well-suited to the present analysis.

Derivation of T_{gap} as the operative bath temperature from BCS theory

Landauer's principle requires specifying the temperature of the heat bath that receives the erasure energy. We derive this temperature from the BCS quasiparticle density of states.

The condensate at the pinhole site can exchange energy only with excitations above the superconducting gap. The BCS density of states for quasiparticle excitations is:

$$N(E) = N_0 \frac{E}{\sqrt{E^2 - \Delta_{\text{Al}}^2}}, \quad E > \Delta_{\text{Al}} \quad (6)$$

with $N(E) = 0$ for $E < \Delta_{\text{Al}}$. The thermal quasiparticle fraction at temperature T is given by the BCS result:

$$x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{th}}(T) \approx 2\sqrt{\frac{2\pi\Delta_{\text{Al}}}{k_B T}} e^{-\Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B T} \quad (7)$$

valid for $k_B T \ll \Delta_{\text{Al}}$. Two candidate heat baths exist at the pinhole site:

Bath A (substrate phonons at T_{fridge}): At $T_{\text{fridge}} = 15 \text{ mK}$, the Boltzmann factor for quasiparticle excitation is $e^{-\Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B T_{\text{fridge}}} \sim e^{-141} \sim 10^{-61}$. The phonon bath cannot mediate pair-breaking at this temperature; it is effectively decoupled from the condensate as a bath for QP-generating processes.

Bath B (quasiparticle continuum above the gap): The effective temperature at which the quasiparticle bath becomes thermally accessible is set by $k_B T_{\text{eff}} \sim \Delta_{\text{Al}}$, giving:

$$T_{\text{gap}} \equiv \frac{\Delta_{\text{Al}}}{k_B} = 2.11 \text{ K} \quad (8)$$

At T_{gap} , the thermal quasiparticle fraction from Eq. (7) is of order unity, confirming that the QP bath is fully accessible at this temperature.

The erasure events in our model produce quasiparticles by construction — each erasure deposits energy $\Delta_{\text{Al}} \ln 2$ into the condensate, generating $\ln 2$ quasiparticles. The bath that *receives* the erasure energy is therefore the quasiparticle bath, whose effective temperature

is T_{gap} . The identification $T_H = T_{\text{gap}}$ is the unique self-consistent choice: any other bath temperature would either be thermally inaccessible for QP-generating erasure (if $T < T_{\text{gap}}$) or would imply a different gap scale (if $T > T_{\text{gap}}$). No free parameter is introduced; T_{gap} is fixed by the material gap Δ_{Al} alone.

This derivation makes a sharp, parameter-free prediction: $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$ is independent of T_{fridge} for all $T_{\text{fridge}} \ll T_{\text{gap}} = 2.11$ K, i.e., below ~ 150 mK. This prediction is consistent with Ristè *et al.* [2], who observed no dependence of x_{qp} on T_{fridge} below 150 mK. Any model in which T_{fridge} is the relevant bath temperature would struggle to explain this observation.

Derivation of the Landauer erasure mapping

We now show that TLS-induced decoherence of the condensate phase at a pinhole site constitutes a Landauer erasure process in the sense of Bennett [18].

Consider the joint state of the condensate phase ϕ and the TLS at a single pinhole site. The TLS couples to the condensate phase via the junction admittance, with coupling strength g . Measured TLS-qubit coupling strengths in Al/AlOx/Al junctions are $g/2\pi \sim 1\text{--}10$ MHz [15, 16], compared to qubit transition frequencies $\omega_q/2\pi \sim 5$ GHz. A single TLS flip ($|s\rangle \rightarrow |s'\rangle$) imprints a phase kick on the condensate of order:

$$\delta\phi \sim \frac{g}{\omega_q} \sim 10^{-3} \text{ rad} \quad (9)$$

This is small compared to 2π , placing the system firmly in the perturbative regime. The precise value of $\delta\phi$ does not enter the Landauer energy bound: the minimum erasure cost $k_B T_{\text{gap}} \ln 2$ holds for any nonzero phase kick, provided the subsequent restoration is irreversible. The perturbative condition $\delta\phi \ll 1$ is required only to justify treating each TLS flip as an independent erasure event, which the timescale separation below confirms independently.

The condensate restores its phase via dissipative relaxation on a timescale:

$$\tau_\phi \sim \frac{\hbar}{\Delta_{\text{Al}}} \approx 3.6 \text{ fs} \quad (10)$$

This is faster than the TLS flip timescale by a factor:

$$\frac{\tau_\phi}{\tau_{\text{TLS}}} \sim \frac{\hbar/\Delta_{\text{Al}}}{\tau_{\text{TLS}}} \approx \frac{3.6 \text{ fs}}{30 \text{ } \mu\text{s}} \approx 10^{-10} \quad (11)$$

The timescale separation $\tau_\phi \ll \tau_{\text{TLS}}$ has two consequences. First, each TLS flip constitutes a complete, independent erasure event before the next flip occurs. Second, the erasure events are statistically independent, producing Poissonian QPT statistics — consistent with Ref. [11]. In open-quantum-systems language, $\tau_\phi \ll \tau_{\text{TLS}}$

is precisely the Markovian limit: the condensate memory of each perturbation decays on a timescale ($\sim$ fs) far shorter than the inter-event interval ($\sim \tau_{\text{TLS}}$), so each TLS flip is an independent Lindblad jump event with the minimum dissipation set by the Landauer-Bennett bound.

The logical irreversibility arises as follows. After a TLS flip, the condensate phase carries information about which TLS state caused the perturbation ($|s\rangle$ or $|s'\rangle$). The subsequent dissipative restoration $\phi_0 + \delta\phi \rightarrow \phi_0$ discards this information: the restored condensate state is identical regardless of the direction of the preceding TLS flip. This irreversible discarding of one bit of information about the TLS state is precisely a Landauer erasure [17, 18]. The minimum energy dissipated is:

$$E_{\text{erase}} = k_B T_{\text{gap}} \ln 2 = \frac{\Delta_{\text{Al}}}{k_B} \cdot k_B \ln 2 = \Delta_{\text{Al}} \ln 2 \quad (12)$$

The identification $T_H = T_{\text{gap}}$ from the bath temperature derivation above enters here: the bath temperature in the Landauer bound is that of the quasiparticle bath. The result $E_{\text{erase}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}} \ln 2$ is exact and parameter-free, following from $T_{\text{gap}} = \Delta_{\text{Al}}/k_B$.

The number of quasiparticles generated per erasure event follows immediately:

$$N_{\text{QP}} = \frac{E_{\text{erase}}}{\Delta_{\text{Al}}} = \ln 2 \quad (13)$$

This is the origin of $\ln 2$ in the formula for $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$: it is not a fitting constant but the Landauer entropy per bit, emerging from the erasure physics.

DERIVATION

Assembling the three results of the Theoretical Foundations section above: the Landauer erasure energy per event (Eq. 12), the quasiparticle yield (Eq. 13), and the participation volume (Eq. 5), we obtain the quasiparticle generation rate per pinhole site and the resulting steady-state density.

The Landauer cost per erasure event is:

$$E_L = k_B T_{\text{gap}} \ln 2 = \Delta_{\text{Al}} \ln 2 \quad (14)$$

Each refresh event generates $E_L/\Delta_{\text{Al}} = \ln 2 \approx 0.693$ quasiparticles on average (energy deposited divided by energy per QP). The quasiparticle generation rate per pinhole site is:

$$\Gamma_{\text{qp}} = \frac{1}{\tau_{\text{TLS}}} \cdot \frac{E_L}{\Delta_{\text{Al}}} = \frac{\ln 2}{\tau_{\text{TLS}}} \quad (15)$$

At steady state, the QP number density within the participation volume $V_{\text{eff}} = \pi \lambda_L^3$ (Eq. 5) is:

$$n_{\text{qp}} = \frac{\Gamma_{\text{qp}} \cdot \tau_{\text{qp}}}{V_{\text{eff}}} = \frac{\ln 2 \cdot \tau_{\text{qp}}}{\tau_{\text{TLS}} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3} \quad (16)$$

The normalized quasiparticle fraction is:

$$x_{qp}^{\min} = \frac{n_{qp}}{n_{cp}} = \frac{\ln 2 \cdot \tau_{qp}}{n_{cp} \cdot \tau_{TLS} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3} \quad (17)$$

Equivalently, rearranging Eq. (17) defines a dimensionless invariant:

$$\frac{x_{qp}^{\min} \cdot n_{cp} \cdot \tau_{TLS} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3}{\tau_{qp}} = \ln 2 \quad (18)$$

This relation holds exactly for any device in which the endogenous Landauer mechanism dominates, independent of the specific value of τ_{TLS} . All five quantities on the left are independently measurable on the same device.

Numerical evaluation

We evaluate Eq. (17) using the following published parameters:

- $T_{gap} = \Delta_{Al}/k_B = 2.112$ K, with $\Delta_{Al} = 182$ μ eV (median from Kurter *et al.* [8]: 183–193 μ eV)
- $\tau_{TLS} = 30$ μ s (Burnett *et al.* [12]: published range 1–100 μ s for 1/f fluctuators in superconducting resonators)
- $\tau_{qp} = 100$ μ s (Lenander *et al.* [13]; Serniak *et al.* [14]: published range 100–200 μ s)
- $n_{cp} = 9.03 \times 10^{28}$ m⁻³ (Al BCS: 3 valence electrons, FCC lattice $a = 4.05$ Å, $n_{cp} = n_e/2$ [21])
- $\lambda_L = 50$ nm (Al thin film; Kurter *et al.* [8], citing Greytak & Wernick [9])

This gives:

$$\begin{aligned} x_{qp}^{\min} &= \frac{\ln 2 \cdot \tau_{qp}}{n_{cp} \cdot \tau_{TLS} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3} \\ &= \frac{0.693 \times 100 \mu s}{9.03 \times 10^{28} \text{ m}^{-3} \times 30 \mu s \times \pi (50 \text{ nm})^3} \\ &= 6.5 \times 10^{-8} \end{aligned} \quad (19)$$

The published background floor in best-isolated Al/AlOx transmons is $x_{qp} \sim 10^{-7}$ [1, 2, 7]. Our result is within a factor of 1.5 using only published material parameters and no adjustable parameters: every input is drawn from independent measurements on Al or AlOx.

The factor of 1.5 corresponds to $\tau_{TLS} \approx 20$ μ s giving exact agreement, well within the published range of 1–100 μ s. This sensitivity to τ_{TLS} is expected and is itself testable (see the Falsifiable Predictions section and Fig. 2).

Figure 2. Model Prediction: $x_{qp}^{\min}$ vs TLS Correlation Time
Formula intersects observed floor ($\sim 10^{-7}$) at $\tau_{TLS} \approx 20 \mu$ s, within published AlOx range (Burnett *et al.* 2014)

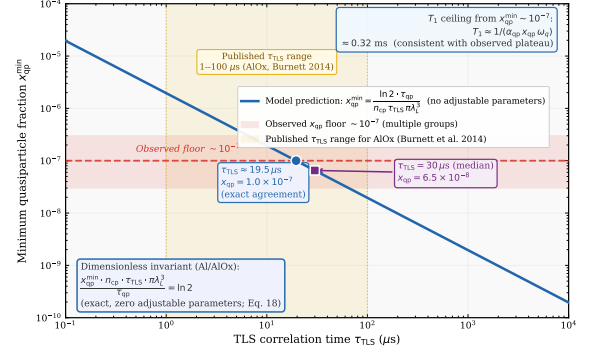


FIG. 2. Prediction for $x_{qp}^{\min}$ as a function of the TLS correlation time τ_{TLS} from Eq. (17). The blue line is the model prediction using published material parameters and no adjustable fit parameters. The red band marks the published observed floor $x_{qp} \sim 10^{-7}$ in best-isolated Al/AlOx transmons [1, 2, 7]. The yellow band marks the published range of τ_{TLS} for AlOx fluctuators at millikelvin [12]. The formula intersects the observed floor at $\tau_{TLS} \approx 15$ – 30 μ s, within the published range. The dimensionless invariant (Eq. 18) is the falsifiable prediction: measuring x_{qp} , τ_{TLS} , λ_L , n_{cp} , and τ_{qp} on the same device tests whether their combination equals $\ln 2$. Upper right: the implied T_1 ceiling ≈ 0.32 ms from $x_{qp} \sim 10^{-7}$, consistent with the observed plateau in best-isolated Al/AlOx transmons.

CONSISTENCY WITH PUBLISHED OBSERVATIONS

Table I summarizes the consistency of the endogenous Landauer mechanism with nine published observations. We note that several of these observations were previously unexplained within the exogenous (radiation-dominated) framework.

FALSIFIABLE PREDICTIONS

Equation (18) gives the dimensionless invariant for Al/AlOx:

$$\frac{x_{qp}^{\min} \cdot n_{cp} \cdot \tau_{TLS} \cdot \pi \lambda_L^3}{\tau_{qp}} = \ln 2 \approx 0.693 \quad (20)$$

Inserting the published parameters from the numerical evaluation above (where $x_{qp}^{\min} = 6.5 \times 10^{-8}$ is rounded from 6.52×10^{-8}), the numerator evaluates to:

$$\begin{aligned} &(6.52 \times 10^{-8})(9.03 \times 10^{28})(30 \mu s)(\pi)(50 \text{ nm})^3 \\ &\approx 6.94 \times 10^{-5} \text{ s m}^3 \end{aligned} \quad (21)$$

Dividing by $\tau_{qp} = 100$ μ s gives $0.694 \approx \ln 2$. ✓
This leads to three specific predictions:

TABLE I. Consistency of the endogenous Landauer mechanism with published observations. The “Status” column distinguishes observations that *rule out* specific alternative explanations from those that are *positively consistent with* the proposed mechanism.

Observation	Reference	Endogenous explanation	Status
Equilibrium energy distribution with excess density	Connolly <i>et al.</i> [7]	Continuous endogenous source; QPs thermalize to gap edge faster than τ_{qp} . External sources give excess energy.	Positively consistent
Underground operation: no T_1 improvement	Ref. [6]	Rules out cosmic radiation as dominant source at current qubit lifetimes.	Rules out exogenous
T_1 robust to shielding; QPT rate sensitive	Gordon <i>et al.</i> [10]	T_1 limited by endogenous floor; QPT rate sensitive to exogenous $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{exog}}$.	Rules out shielding fix
Background QPT Poissonian statistics	Ref. [11]	Independent Markovian erasure events produce Poissonian statistics. Burst sources (cosmic rays) are non-Poissonian.	Positively consistent
x_{qp} independent of T_{fridge} below 150 mK	Ristè <i>et al.</i> [2]	Landauer cost set by $T_{\text{gap}} = 2.11$ K, not T_{fridge} .	Positively consistent
TLS primarily on junction leads	Lisenfeld <i>et al.</i> [15]	Junction leads are the encoding surface driving the Landauer refresh rate.	Positively consistent
TLS and QP populations coupled	Ref. [16]	Landauer QPs trap in gap inhomogeneities, forming qTLS species that add to TLS bath.	Positively consistent
QPT scales with encoding surface area	Kurter <i>et al.</i> [8]	More pinhole sites means higher total Landauer cost.	Positively consistent
Quantitative: $x_{\text{qp}} \sim 10^{-7}$	Multiple groups	Eq. (17) gives 6.5×10^{-8} , within factor of 1.5.	Quantitative agreement

Prediction 1 (same-device invariant test): The dimensionless invariant (Eq. 18) is testable from a single device by measuring all five quantities — x_{qp} , n_{cp} , τ_{TLS} , λ_L , and τ_{qp} — on the same platform and checking whether their combination equals $\ln 2$. This is the decisive test: existing data draw from multiple device families and measurement modalities, so this same-device measurement would constitute the first direct test of the invariant. The quantities τ_{TLS} and x_{qp} are both measurable on a single transmon via 1/f noise spectroscopy and parity-switch statistics respectively. Specifically, $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} \cdot \tau_{\text{TLS}} = \text{const}$ for fixed material parameters: devices with improved AlOx barriers (longer τ_{TLS}) should show proportionally lower $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$.

Prediction 2 (temperature independence): $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$ should be independent of T_{fridge} for all $T_{\text{fridge}} \lesssim 150$ mK. This prediction is consistent with Ristè *et al.* [2], who observed no change in x_{qp} as T_{fridge} was varied below 150 mK. Any model in which the relevant bath temperature is T_{fridge} would struggle to explain this observation.

Prediction 3 (material scaling): For a different superconducting material with different λ_L , gap temper-

ature, and Cooper pair density, Eq. (17) predicts a different $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$ floor. The ratio of floors between two materials depends only on their ratio of $\lambda_L^3 \cdot n_{\text{cp}}$ values — independently measurable material properties.

IMPLICATIONS FOR COHERENCE LIMITS

The QP-induced relaxation rate is [19]:

$$\Gamma_1^{\text{qp}} = \alpha_{\text{qp}} \cdot x_{\text{qp}} \cdot \omega_q \quad (22)$$

where $\alpha_{\text{qp}} \approx 1$ is a dimensionless coupling factor. For $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} \sim 10^{-7}$ and $\omega_q/2\pi = 5$ GHz, this gives $T_1^{\text{ceiling}} \approx 0.3$ ms — consistent with the observed plateau in best-isolated Al/AlOx transmons.

This ceiling is *endogenous* and, within this framework, cannot be reduced by improved shielding, substrate engineering, or fabrication improvements to external components. Unlike dielectric loss from TLS (reducible by surface treatment) or T_1 limits from external radiation (reducible by shielding), the Landauer floor is set by the maintenance cost of quantum coherence itself against the

TLS bath intrinsic to the AlOx barrier. It can only be reduced by changing the fundamental material parameters — for instance, by replacing AlOx with a barrier material having a longer τ_{TLS} (Prediction 1) or a smaller $\lambda_L^3 \cdot n_{\text{cp}}^{-1}$ ratio (Prediction 3).

DISCUSSION

The result that $x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}}$ is endogenous rather than exogenous has a straightforward implication: engineering efforts to reduce the background QP floor through better shielding, underground operation, or gap engineering will not improve T_1 beyond the predicted Landauer ceiling within this framework. Recent best-in-class Al/AlOx and Nb/AlOx transmon devices achieving $T_1 \sim 300 \mu\text{s}$ [20] are already within a factor of a few of this ceiling.

The mechanism identified here — continuous Landauer maintenance cost paid at the junction’s high-transmission pinhole sites — provides a candidate explanation for several phenomena that have previously been treated as separate: the persistent background x_{qp} , the TLS-QP coupling observed by de Graaf *et al.* [16], and the equilibrium energy distribution of Connolly *et al.* [7]. All three are consistent with the same process: the thermodynamic cost of maintaining quantum coherence against the TLS bath at the junction encoding surface.

We propose a framework, not a proof. The central physical identifications — the erasure mapping, the T_{gap} bath, and the $\pi\lambda_L^3$ participation volume — are derived from established theory in the Theoretical Foundations section above and are internally self-consistent. Whether they are the *unique* correct description of the system is an experimental question. The answer lies in Prediction 1: a same-device measurement of all five quantities in Eq. (18) that either returns $\ln 2$ or does not. We are not aware of a more direct test of the proposed mechanism that could be performed on existing device platforms.

CONCLUSION

We have proposed a Landauer-based thermodynamic model for the minimum quasiparticle density in Al/AlOx/Al transmon qubits. The three central assumptions — the Landauer erasure mapping, the T_{gap} bath temperature, and the $\pi\lambda_L^3$ participation volume — are each derived from BCS theory and the London equations in the Theoretical Foundations section above.

$$x_{\text{qp}}^{\text{min}} = \frac{\ln 2 \cdot \tau_{\text{qp}}}{n_{\text{cp}} \cdot \tau_{\text{TLS}} \cdot \pi\lambda_L^3} = 6.5 \times 10^{-8} \quad (23)$$

contains no adjustable parameters and uses only published material constants. It is consistent with nine independent observations and makes three specific falsifiable

predictions. The underground laboratory result — identical T_1 at surface and at Gran Sasso despite a factor-of-thirty reduction in muon flux — rules out cosmic radiation as the dominant source at current qubit lifetimes, consistent with an endogenous origin.

The background x_{qp} floor may reflect an endogenous thermodynamic maintenance cost of quantum coherence, paid continuously whether the qubit is being used or not, rather than solely an external noise source to be engineered away.

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